‘so far as the security of the Suez Canal is affected’, Persia, the Persian Gulf and Afghanistan.

Since Delhi retained consulates in southern Persia and held ultimate control of Afghanistan’s foreign relations, such an arrangement appeared reasonable.[8] And naturally, the First World War was just such a ‘special case’ that India contributed unreservedly to the British cause. Together with supplying a quarter of a million native troops to serve in Mesopotamia, Persia, the Caucasus and Transcaspia, in 1917 India made an outright gift of £100 million towards the war effort – almost double India’s net revenue before the outbreak of the conflict.[9]

The result of such an expansion of Indian involvement in southern Asia during the war was both a greater desire of the Indian government to have a political say befitting its military and financial responsibilities and a general confusion of jurisdiction between the Foreign, War and India Offices. In Persia, for example, General Malleson’s mission at Meshed and Sir Percy Sykes’ South Persia Rifles (SPR),[10] were both Indian government contingents, yet Dunsterforce, in the north-west of that country, was under the command of the War Office.[11] The tradition of having both Foreign Office and Indian controlled consulates in Persia was also problematic. As Montagu pointed out in July 1918, such a set-up meant that Britain effectively had two voices within Persia.[12] In Mesopotamia, Indian troops were instrumental in preventing the country from falling into Turkish hands. However, by 1917 military operations were transferred to the War Office, even though India continued to supply the men and material for the rest of the war, and the civil administration of that country also remained under Indian control.[13] For the government of India, by the summer of 1918 this confusion of authority was becoming increasingly unacceptable, particularly when it was coupled with a lack of political say on India’s part. As Montagu pointed out during a debate of the Eastern Committee on Persia, not allowing India to have political control in that country meant that ‘the Indian Government naturally said: “why should we give our men and our money to the prosecution of a policy of which we disapprove”’.[14] The solution to both problems, as Montagu saw it, was to have ‘the whole